MASALA MEMSAHIB: Recipes and Stories from My Culinary Adventures in India
by Karen Anand
PAN MACMILLAN
₹1,999; 240 pages





BOOKS

Making It Easy

Karen Anand says her new culinary memoir is a response to the fast, hectic pace of our lives

HOW OFTEN DO WE DWELL on the origins of the food on our plate? For instance, *chingri malai kari*, which literally translates to 'prawns in a creamy curry', gives one an impression that the prawns are cooked in a creamy, milk-derived concoction. In Karen Anand's *Masala Memsahib*, the dish features in her section on West Bengal, yes, but here she writes that word 'malai' refers to Malay (Malaysia) from where the recipe supposedly drew its inspiration. She also writes about how Mulligatawny, the famous peppery soup from Tamil Nadu, traces its origins to the colonial era, from a time when Englishmen were beginning to warm up to



London's St John Bread & Wine, founded by chef Fergus Henderson of *Nose to Tail Eating* fame, is not known for a menu bursting with masalas. But while head chef Farokh Talati capably oversees its elegantly rustic, British-inspired plates of meats and veg, he has also been exploring his own family's Parsi food through pop-up dinners, and now his first cookbook. Conceived during the pandemic, *Parsi: Recipes & Tales from the Ancient Culture* is a charming, personal introduction to the cuisine by someone who discovered it from the outside-in.

Based on family dishes gleaned from Talati's trips to India (he was born and grew up in the UK), as well as his own experimentation, *Parsi* includes over 150 recipes. Not all of them are traditional, but they feel at home flavour-wise among the classics, and seem in keeping with the Parsi spirit of adaptation.

Eschewing authoritative claims, Talati describes the provenance of recipes as they came to him: from his Dinaz Aunty, his uncle Adil, a Tirgan festival tradition in Iran, or simply a moment of inspiration during a rushed catering gig.

After all, Talati writes, "that is what Parsi cooking has always been about, taking the best bits from here and there to create something wonderful."

This is a book to savour as much as cook from. Talati's writing is evocative and unpretentious; just sample his personification of dhansak masala as "the older sibling, more refined, more experienced in life and quietly confident" as opposed to sambhar masala, the "younger brasher sibling". The book's styling and photography reflect a playful approach to cooking and ingredients, embracing splatter and gesture.

The recipes range from easy (mango pickle mayonnaise) to more advanced; but,

THE PARSI FOOD CHAIN

In a sumptuous new book, ***chef Farokh Talati*** *shows how Parsi cuisine came to be irresistible*